

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Indian Philosophy: Schools of Vedanta

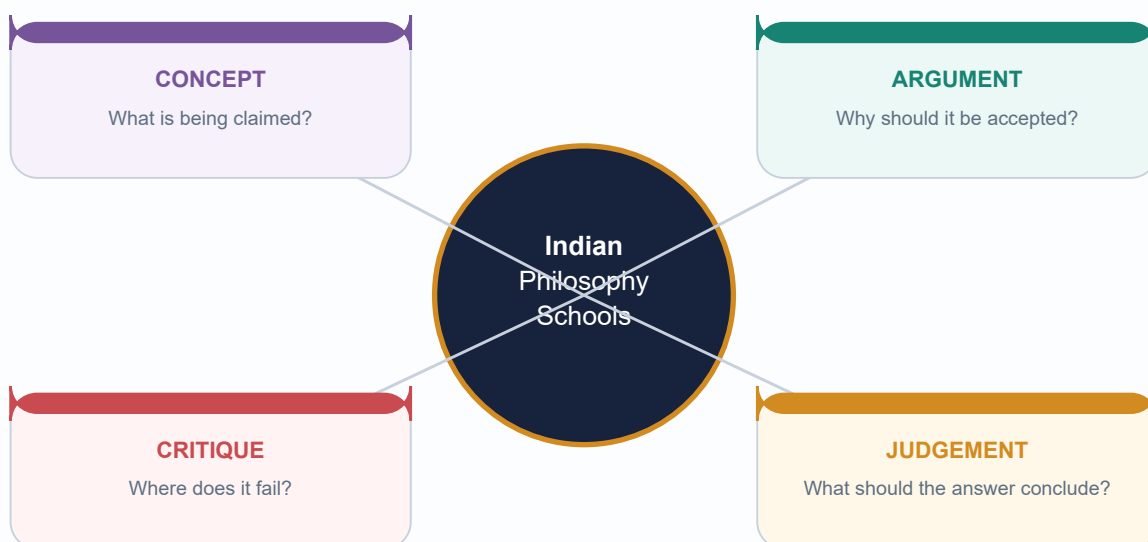
UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Indian Philosophy

Visual learning edition: central maps, argument flows, comparisons and PYQ frameworks

Syllabus: Brahman; Isvara; Atman; Jiva; Jagat; Maya; Avidya; Adhyasa; Moksa; Aprthaksiddhi; Pancavidhabheda.

Direct-source base: Chatterjee and Datta, Vedanta chapter (local PDF pp. 270-339); C. D. Sharma, pre-Sankara, Sankara, post-Sankara, Ramanuja and other Vedanta chapters (printed pp. 227-373); Radhakrishnan, Indian Philosophy Vol. II, Vedanta Sutra, Sankara, Ramanuja, and later theism chapters.

Cross-checked with Paper I PYQs, 2022-2025.



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Central Mind Map: Three Readings of Brahman-Jiva-Jagat

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Vedanta schools share the Upanisads, Bhagavad Gita, and Brahma Sutra but disagree over whether difference is appearance, a real qualification of unity, or an eternal feature of reality.

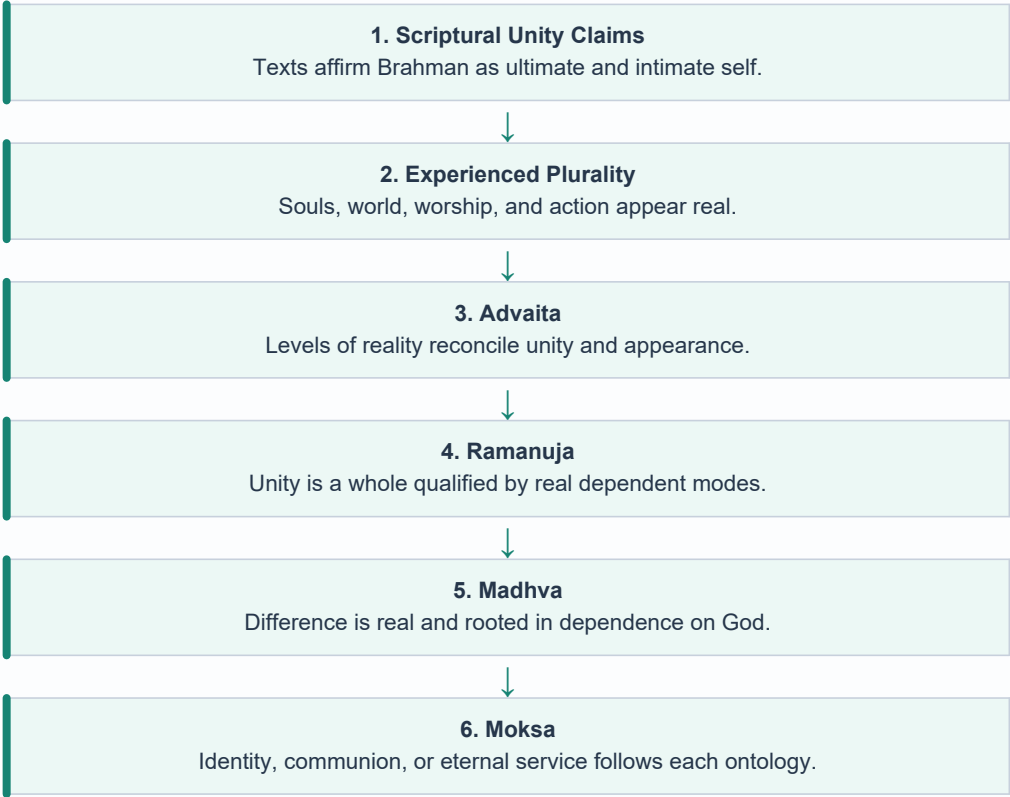
This PDF focuses on the syllabus triad: Sankara's Advaita, Ramanuja's Visistadvaita, and Madhva's Dvaita. Later internal Advaita theories are included only where recent PYQs require them.

VEDANTA MASTER MAP

HOW ARE BRAHMAN, JIVA, AND JAGAT RELATED?

Advaita Brahman alone is ultimate; plurality is dependent appearance.	Visistadvaita One qualified Brahman includes real souls and matter as body or modes.
Dvaita God, souls, and matter are eternally and really different.	Maya-Avidya Advaita explains appearance and ignorance.
Aprthaksiddhi Ramanuja explains inseparable but real distinction.	Pancabheda Madhva articulates five eternal differences.

SHARED PROBLEM, DIVERGENT SOLUTIONS



MEMORY HOOK

A-V-D: Absolute non-duality; Visista unity-with-real-difference; Dvaita eternal difference.

CONCEPT LINKS

Vedanta Concept	Linked Doctrine	Exam Value
Vivartavada	Samkhya parinamavada	Appearance versus real transformation.
Maya	Buddhist sunyata	Compare carefully; Advaita affirms Brahman.
Aprthaksiddhi	Samavaya	Inseparable qualification versus Nyaya inherence.
Pancabheda	Advaita identity	Difference versus non-dual sublation.

MAINS ANGLE

The Vedanta debate is not whether Brahman is ultimate, but what kind of unity can preserve scripture, experience, and liberation.

STUDY LINK

Official syllabus item 19; answer through a three-school comparison whenever wording permits.

HIGH

Advaita Technical Terms: Brahman, Maya, Avidya, Adhyasa

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Advaita distinguishes absolute Brahman from Brahman as Isvara within empirical experience. Bondage begins with adhyasa, the mutual superimposition of self and not-self.

KEY DATA

Term	Advaita Account	Exam Use
Brahman	Non-dual reality, pure being-consciousness-bliss, beyond limiting attributes.	Ultimate ontological claim.
Isvara	Brahman associated with maya as omniscient empirical Lord.	Theism within vyavahara.
Atman	Inner self identical with Brahman.	Mahavakya interpretation.
Jiva	Consciousness apparently limited by mind and avidya.	Bondage and reflection theories.
Jagat	Empirically functioning appearance dependent on Brahman.	Avoid simple non-existence.
Maya	Cosmic power of projection and concealment; neither absolutely real nor sheer unreal.	World appearance.
Avidya	Ignorance at the individual or explanatory level.	Cause of misidentification.
Adhyasa	Superimposition of self and non-self characteristics.	Root mechanism of bondage.
Moksa	Removal of ignorance through knowledge of identity.	Attainment of what is already attained.
Three realities	Absolute, empirical, and illusory.	Resolve contradictions across levels.

ADHYASA TO MOKSA**STATIC THEORY**

- **Vivartavada:** the world is an apparent transformation, not a real change in Brahman.
- **Material and efficient cause:** Brahman is spoken of as both, but causality belongs to the empirical explanatory level.
- **Tat tvam asi:** limiting adjuncts are set aside to reveal identity of consciousness.
- **Bimba-pratibimba:** one consciousness appears as Isvara and jiva through different reflecting conditions.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Mithya means dependent and sublatale, not sheer non-existence.
2. Isvara is not denied at the empirical level.
3. Moksa is knowledge, not production of a new relation.

MAINS ANGLE

Advaita preserves non-duality by grading reality, but critics question whether maya can be coherently related to Brahman.

STUDY LINK

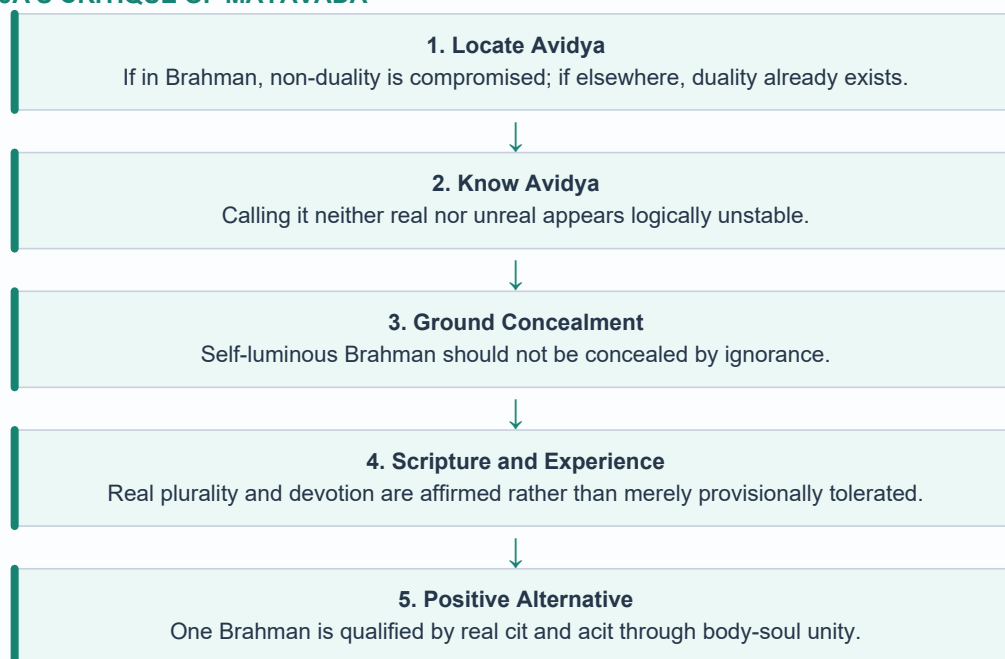
Use adhyasa as the causal bridge from metaphysics to soteriology.

HIGH**Ramanuja and Madhva: Aprthaksiddhi and Fivefold Difference**Paper I
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Ramanuja rejects an attributeless absolute and unreal world; Madhva radicalizes real difference while making all finite reality dependent on God.

KEY DATA

Issue	Visistadvaita	Dvaita
Brahman	Personal, qualified by infinite auspicious qualities.	Personal supreme Visnu, wholly independent.
Jiva	Real conscious mode, distinct yet inseparable from God.	Real dependent self, eternally distinct.
Jagat	Real material mode and body of God.	Real dependent world.
Aprthaksiddhi	Cit and acit cannot exist apart from Brahman yet remain distinct.	Not central.
Body-soul relation	Souls and matter are God's body; God is inner ruler.	Dependence does not erase difference.
Moksa	Loving communion and service; individuality remains.	Eternal service with real distinction and gradation.
Path	Bhakti and surrender aided by grace.	Bhakti, right knowledge of difference, and grace.
Pancavidhabheda	Not accepted as ultimate fivefold separation.	God-soul, God-matter, soul-soul, soul-matter, matter-matter.

RAMANUJA'S CRITIQUE OF MAYAVADA**STATIC THEORY**

- **Sapta-anupapatti:** Ramanuja's seven objections target locus, concealment, nature, proof, removal, and explanatory use of avidya.
- **Aprthaksiddhi:** inseparability is not identity; the mode depends on the whole while retaining real character.
- **Madhva's hierarchy:** dependence and difference structure reality; liberation does not erase individuality.
- **Body-soul analogy:** unity is organic and qualified, not a collection of independent substances.

MEMORY HOOK

RAMANUJA: ONE WHOLE WITH REAL MODES. MADHVA: FIVE REAL DIFFERENCES UNDER ONE SUPREME GOD.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

- 1. Ramanuja's world is real, not a lower-grade illusion.
- 2. Madhva's difference is positive and eternal.
- 3. Both reject the Advaita claim that liberation culminates in identity without distinction.

MAINS ANGLE

Ramanuja and Madhva preserve devotion and moral agency by making difference real, but must explain how dependence and plurality coexist with divine unity.

STUDY LINK

Use the body-soul relation for 2024 and the seven objections for 2025.

HIGH

Strongest Criticism-Defence and Three-School Comparison

Paper I
Philosophy

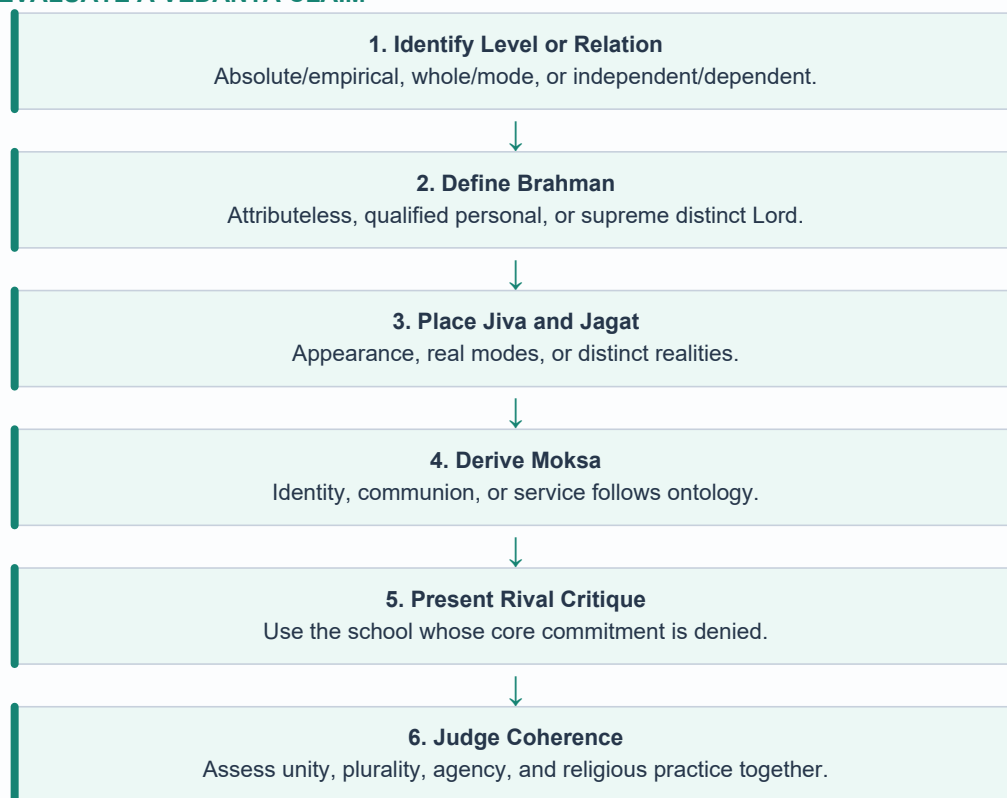
INTRO & ORIGIN

Each Vedanta school solves one problem by accepting another burden: Advaita maximizes unity, Visistadvaita preserves organic plurality, and Dvaita preserves difference.

KEY DATA

School	Strongest Criticism	Best Defence
Advaita	Maya is inexplicable: a second principle threatens non-duality, yet unreality cannot explain appearance.	Maya is not a second absolute; it marks the dependent, sublatale status of empirical experience.
Visistadvaita	If souls and matter are real parts or modes, Brahman seems affected by their defects.	Body-soul dependence does not transfer every bodily defect to the inner ruler.
Dvaita	Eternal difference appears to limit divine unity and makes liberation permanently unequal.	God's unity is supremacy and independence, not numerical absorption of all difference.
Advaita theism	A merely empirical Isvara seems religiously downgraded.	Theistic devotion remains valid and indispensable within the path to knowledge.
Identity and agency	If jiva is never truly bound, who seeks liberation?	Bondage belongs to the empirical standpoint and is removed through empirical discipline and knowledge.

HOW TO EVALUATE A VEDANTA CLAIM



THREE-SCHOOL COMPARISON

Axis	Advaita	Visistadvaita / Dvaita
World	Dependent appearance	Real mode / real distinct world
Jiva	Ultimately identical	Distinct dependent self
God	Isvara within empirical order	Supreme personal ultimate
Moksa	Knowledge of identity	Communion or service
Causation	Vivarta	Real transformation / real dependence

MAINS ANGLE

No Vedanta school can be evaluated by metaphysics alone; its account of worship, agency, and liberation is the practical test of its ontology.

STUDY LINK

Use ontology -> relation -> path -> moksa as the comparison sequence.

HIGH

PYQ Routes and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

Paper I
Philosophy

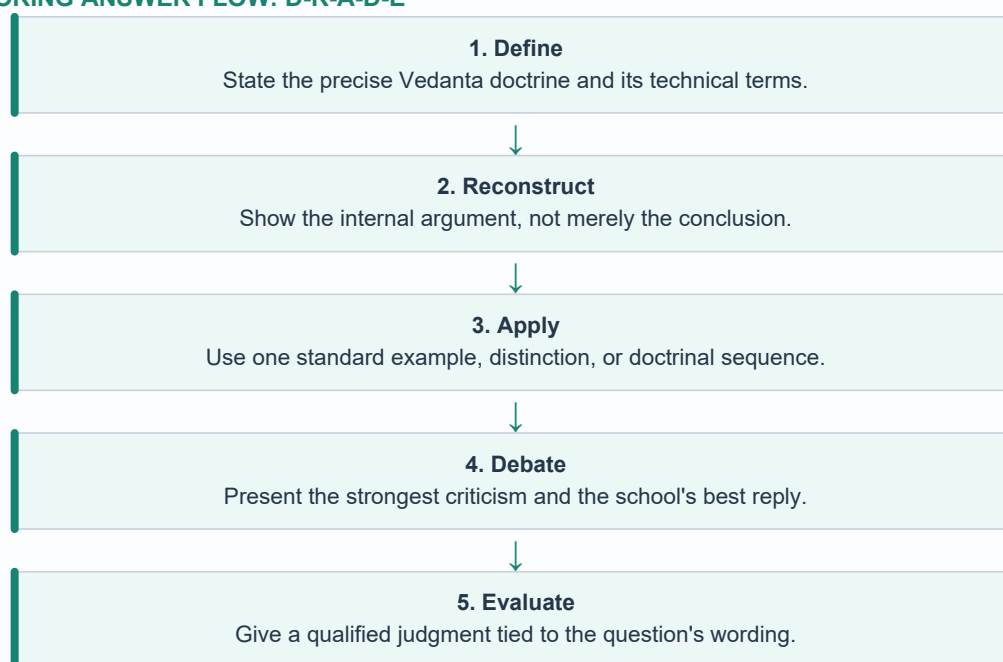
INTRO & ORIGIN

UPSC repeatedly tests a narrow doctrine through comparison, internal tension, criticism, or an applied example. The answer should reconstruct the school's reasoning before evaluating it.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 10	Vivartavada as development of parinamavada.	Appearance and transformation.
2022 / 20	Status of Isvara, jiva, and saksin in Advaita.	Levels and reflection/limitation.
2022 / 15	Madhva and Ramanuja on moksa.	Difference, communion, service.
2023 / 20	Ramanuja's criticism of Sankara's Brahman and Isvara.	Qualified personal absolute versus nirguna.
2023 / 15	Liberation as attainment of the already attained.	Ignorance removal, illustrations.
2024 / 10	God-world relation as self-body in Visistadvaita.	Organic dependence and reality.
2025 / 10	Ramanuja's seven objections to Mayavada.	Sapta-anupapatti.
2025 / 20	Bimba-pratibimbavada and soteriology.	One consciousness, reflections, removal of ignorance.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER FLOW: D-R-A-D-E



STATIC THEORY

- **10 marks:** identify the school, define the technical term, explain the relation with one analogy, add one rival objection.
- **15 marks:** reconstruct ontology and soteriology together, compare one rival school, and offer a qualified assessment.
- **20 marks:** distinguish levels or modes, explain internal theories, present the strongest cross-school criticism, defend, and conclude on coherence of unity and difference.
- **Applied drill:** Use the rope-snake case to distinguish pratibhasika, vyavaharika, and paramarthika reality.
- **Applied drill:** Apply the body-soul analogy to God-world relation, then state why Advaita and Dvaita reject Ramanuja's account.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Write the Sanskrit technical term once, then explain it in plain language.
2. Separate exposition, criticism, defence, and final assessment.
3. Use comparison only where it clarifies the precise issue asked.
4. For statement questions, interpret the statement before presenting doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Mithya means absolutely non-existent.

CORRECT: It means dependent, empirically functioning, and sublatale. Avoid nihilist reading.

WRONG: Ramanuja's cit and acit are independent substances.

CORRECT: They are real but inseparable dependent modes/body of Brahman. Explains qualified unity.

WRONG: Dvaita teaches only two differences.

CORRECT: It articulates five types of real difference. Use the full list.

WRONG: All Vedanta schools give the same moksa.

CORRECT: Identity, communion, and service differ with ontology. Essential comparison.

UPSC TRAPS AND CORRECTIONS

Common Trap	Correction	Answer Use
Mithya means absolutely non-existent.	It means dependent, empirically functioning, and sublatale.	Avoid nihilist reading.
Ramanuja's cit and acit are independent substances.	They are real but inseparable dependent modes/body of Brahman.	Explains qualified unity.
Dvaita teaches only two differences.	It articulates five types of real difference.	Use the full list.
All Vedanta schools give the same moksa.	Identity, communion, and service differ with ontology.	Essential comparison.

MAINS ANGLE

Vedanta's enduring debate concerns whether the highest unity must negate, qualify, or eternally include difference; high-scoring answers show how each answer reshapes God, world, self, and liberation.

STUDY LINK

Revise the master map, doctrine table, criticism-defence grid, and PYQ routes together.